radiologist, diving into the inner events of an individual life from the physique that is presented before him, reading the symptoms of an unease that burns beneath the skin and remains occult even to the owner of that skin. Patwardhan has honed this faculty of second sight for nearly four decades, bringing it to bear on the self as constituted by the interplay between private impulses and social relationships."

Via Adajania's meticulous compilation in *Walking Through Soul City*, we can see that Patwardhan's unusual calibre was evident by the time of his 1979 solo exhibition debut at Art Heritage—Ebrahim and Roshen Alkazi's gallery in New Delhi—and we also see just how quickly his formal ambitions were substantially realised by early masterpieces like *Overbridge* (1981), about which the art historian R. Siva Kumar (whose essay is also here) writes with great insight that "the visible ripples of fraternal empathy that run through these pictures are



not strong enough to integrate and turn everyone into a participant. These are not collective assertions, but moments of subaltern coming together sprinkled with individual despair and defeat."

The great thing about Patwardhan is those initial breakthroughs were followed by more. Sometime after the passing of his direct forbears in the Progressives—V.S. Gaitonde (2001), F.N. Souza (2002) and, especially, Tyeb Mehta (2009) and Husain (2011)—it became increasingly obvious he was probably our greatest living painter. *Walking Through Soul City* makes that distinction explicit. ■

–Vivek Menezes

Object Lessons

Even though its protagonists are inanimate, a new show at the KNMA uses art to tell a rousing story







Photographs by MOHAMMED ROSHAN

Roobina Karode often tells stories with a kind of sound and fury that make them memorable for years. Director and chief curator at New Delhi's Kiran Nadar Museum of Art (KNMA), Karode has recently put together an exhibition–*Inner Life of Things: Around Anatomies and Armatures*–that takes from 15 artists works of both miniature and gigantic proportions and uses them to imagine a world that both pre-dates and outlives the time of humankind on earth. Not all of these artworks are strictly 'new'–you might have seen them in other galleries before–but Karode uses these objects made of paper, steel, and cloth to tell a grand story of religion, partition and climate change.

ROOBINA KARODE'S vision of the world is both brutal and funny, big and small. This kind of simultaneity makes the show unmissable

One enters KNMA Noida–a gargantuan space–through Shambhavi Singh's *Duaar*, a giant sculpture that resembles the legs of a spider. Inside, another of her sculptures looks like the spine of a dinosaur. All of these are made with discarded agricultural instruments. On a wall nearby, you see a thousand white prayer flags, block-printed with Buddhist symbols. Having once fluttered in Ladakh, they now carry prayers in this cavernous hall, making it strangely sacred. These are juxtaposed against Debasish Mukherjee's white paper structures with windows on the sides. He has also arranged white mulmul fabric from his late grandmother's collection and stamped it with black-and-white digital prints–a bejewelled little girl on one side and the portrait of an old widow on the other.

Inner Life leaves one with much to rave about–Rajendar Tiku's small-scale sculptures which explore the ideas of homeland and the trauma of migration, the exquisite shadow and concrete sculptures of buildings by architect Rathin Barman–but, finally, it's the last two rooms that share the grandiose vision of the first area. One is filled with a series of botanical and animal drawings by Reena Saini Kallat that meld and morph birds, animals, and plants of divided nations, suggesting an alternative evolutionary turn that looks at the fragility of ownership. Called 'Hyphenated Lives', the series invents the 'Manyan' tree, a melding of India's Banyan and Pakistan's mango trees. Her 'Deon' sees the artist morph Ireland's red deer and England's lion. The effect is beautiful and bizarre.

Made from paper, Nibha Sikander's hyperreal tiny moths and butterflies pull our gaze closer towards ecological damage. Vibha Galhotra's sinuous map details a changing climate with different-coloured ghungroos and stone. With wars, epidemics and global warming all threatening to end civilisation, the idea of a post-apocalyptic world is something that artists have dabbled with for almost the whole of the 20th century, but Karode's vision of this world is on a scale that is both brutal and funny, big and small. This kind of simultaneity makes the show unmissable. ■

–Ritika Kochhar

*(*Inner Life of Things *is on display at the Kiran Nadar Museum of Art, Noida, until July 30)*